Session Four: Transition

Required Reading: The Interior Castle: Study Edition*, the Third Dwelling Places,* ch. 1 and 2

Additional Reading: Interpretive notes

Explanatory note: One of the interesting aspects of the relationship between knowledge of self and knowledge of God comes up in Teresa's understanding of the soul in the third dwelling places. The third dwelling is the one in which the soul must move beyond listening and understanding to **loving and doing.** "It is the movement of ethical principles into concrete, loving action; so that devotion to God and others, is not simply theory but a way of putting love and values into practice… This stage represents either a point of entry into deeper, transformative relationship with God or the end of the road for those who equate religion (primarily) with its codes, creeds and rituals" (Entering Teresa of Avila's Interior Castle).

"For perfection, as well as its reward, does not consist in spiritual delights but in greater love and in deeds done with greater justice and truth"
(IC, DP III, 2:10).

Essential Points to Discuss:

- Entry into the third dwelling places, according to Teresa, is somewhat of a moral victory for the soul. "…through perseverance and the mercy of God, they have won these battles and have entered the rooms of the third stage… Certainly we are right in calling such a person blessed… The Lord never fails to give a person this security of conscience, which is no small blessing. I said 'security' and I was wrong, for there is no security in this life, so always understand that I mean, 'if he doesn't abandon the path he began on'" (IC, DP III, 1:1).
- Teresa admires persons in the third dwelling places for "guarding themselves against venial sins; they are fond of doing penance and setting aside periods for recollection; they spend their time well, practicing works of charity toward their neighbors; and they are very balanced in their use of speech and dress and in the governing of their household" (IC, DP III, 1:5). However, she cautiously reminds about the necessity of progression in prayer: "…since there is need of still more in order that the soul possess the Lord completely, it is not enough to say we want it [life of prayer] just as this was not enough for the young man whom the Lord told what he must do in order to be perfect" (IC, DP III, 1:6).

  Note: This state in the third dwelling places, though seemingly good and exemplary, is not the summit of spiritual life. One should have the courage to go beyond the security and delight found in external practices and pious exercises.
- Teresa recalls the young man whom the Lord told what one must do in order to be perfect (Matt. 19:16-22). She observes that many are like him, and ordinarily "the great dryness in prayer" comes from this shift in consciousness (see IC, DP III, 1:6). Like the young man in the Gospel, one can go away sad or accept the invitation and move forward (see IC, DP III, 1.7).

- Like the rich young man, the soul is invited to move beyond a methodical relationship with God and enter more deeply into a new, loving relationship with God. "For He must give the reward in conformity with the love we have for Him. And this love... must not be fabricated in our imaginations but proved by deeds. And don't think He needs our works; He needs the determination of our will" (IC, DP III, 1:7).
- "The Lord will give you understanding of them [favors and gifts] so that out of dryness you may draw humility — and not disquiet… Be convinced that where humility is truly present God will give peace and conformity — even though He may never give consolations — by which one will walk with greater contentment than will others with their consolations" (IC, DP III, 1:9). Accordingly, the soul grows more deeply in self-knowledge.

  Note: "We conclude that self-knowledge flows first from this dry night, and that from this knowledge as from its source proceeds the other knowledge of God. Hence, St. Augustine said to God: *'Let me know myself, Lord, I will know You'"* (The Dark Night 1.12:5).
- Teresa goes on to describe some of the imperfections displayed by these well-ordered and upright souls:
  - "His Majesty will try them in some minor matters, and they will go about so disturbed and afflicted…For everything in their minds leads them to think they are **suffering for God, and so they don't come to realize that their disturbance is an imperfection"** (IC, DP III, 2:1-2, emphasis added).
  - They worry about their health, wealth, and prestige. They may experience financial gain, but it's never been enough, and they seek more and more wealth without satisfaction. Teresa observes that such a person "lacks this freedom of spirit" (see IC, DP III, 2:4).
  - "They would like everyone to live a life as well ordered as they do; and please God they will not think their grief is for the faults of others and in their minds turn it into something meritorious" (IC, DP III 2:5).
- "Let us look at our own faults and leave aside those of others, for it is very characteristic of persons with such well-ordered lives to be shocked by everything. Perhaps we could truly learn from the one who shocks us what is most important, even though we may surpass him in external composure and our way of dealing with others. … So, it is better to carry out what our rule says, to strive to live always in silence and hope" (IC, DP III, 2:13).

*"We are fonder of consolations than we are of the cross. Test us, Lord — for you know the truth — so that we may **know ourselves**"* (IC, DP III, 1:9).